General rule – Falling, suffocation, fire and cold · SRD 5.2.1

Four hazards come up often: **falling**, **suffocation**, **burning** and **extreme temperatures**. Each has a simple rule: a damage die, a duration, or a **Constitution** save that can give **Exhaustion**.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Falling: **1d6 bludgeoning per 10 ft** (max 20d6).
2. Breath: **1 + Con mod. minutes** (min 30 s).
3. Out of breath: **1 Exhaustion** at each turn's end.
4. Burning: **1d4 fire** at the start of each turn.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 replaces 2014's death by suffocation with one **Exhaustion** level at the end of each turn.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD has no extreme cold or heat rule. Fix (table rule): Constitution save DC 10 per hour for cold, DC 5 (+1 per hour) for heat; failure: one Exhaustion level.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the danger approaching (icy wind, smoke, crumbling ground).

Step 1 – Fall:

1d6 bludgeoning per 10 ft fallen, maximum 20d6, dealt at the end of the fall. You land Prone.

Step 2 – Breath:

Hold your breath 1 + Con mod. minutes (min 30 s).

Step 3 – Suffocation:

Out of breath, you gain **1 Exhaustion level** at the end of each of your turns.

Step 4 – Burning:

A burning creature takes **1d4 fire** at the start of each of its turns until the fire is put out.

Step 5 – Temperatures:

Table rule: Con save per hour (cold DC 10, heat DC 5 +1/h). Failure: Exhaustion.

Example: Mira falls 30 ft: 3d6 bludgeoning and she's Prone. Later she holds her breath underwater (Con +2: 3 minutes).

Hazard	Effect
Falling	1d6 bludgeoning per 10 ft, max 20d6; Prone
Breath	1 + Con mod. minutes (min 30 s)
Suffocation	1 Exhaustion at each turn's end
Burning	1d4 fire at the start of each turn
Extreme cold (table)	Con DC 10 per hour; failure: Exhaustion
Extreme heat (table)	Con DC 5 (+1 per hour); failure: Exhaustion

⚠ Common questions:

How much fall damage?

1d6 per 10 ft, max 20d6.

When do I land Prone?

At the end of the fall, unless damage is avoided.

How long can I hold my breath?

1 + Con mod. minutes, min 30 s.

What happens next?

1 Exhaustion level at each turn's end.

How do I put out fire?

An action or an effect that extinguishes.

Is cold in the SRD?

No: table rule.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Lower fall damage

Can I reduce the fall? **Option**: yes with Slow Fall.

Falling into water

Does water reduce damage? **Option**: half the dice.

Progressive suffocation

Does the penalty hit at once? **Option**: one level per turn as written.

Armor and cold

Does heavy armor help? **Option**: no, only warm clothing.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Exhaustion

Each level subtracts 2 from d20 rolls; a Long Rest removes one.

Fire

1d4 per turn until extinguished.

Temperatures

Outside the SRD: table rule.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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